October 1965 failed, with the device lost in an avalanche. A second attempt in 1967 succeeded. The Indian government acknowledged its active participation when the initiative became public in 1978. The US administration publicly demurred, but privately admitted that the revelations were largely true.[218]

Even as they cooperated to monitor the Chinese program, as Bundy put it, "keeping the Indians away from nuclear weapons" remained a basic US interest.[219] In March 1966, Rusk noted to Johnson that to be able to "head off" an Indian nuclear weapons program, the US would have to "be more responsive to Indian security needs, preferably in some way that will minimize our own commitment. However, we must recognize that this response would almost certainly involve an increased and more specific US commitment in the subcontinent and would entail important costs in terms of probable reactions of other states." Rusk recommended against giving India a bilateral nuclear assurance at that time. He noted, however, that Johnson could tell Gandhi that "if a growing Chinese Communist nuclear capability should ever pose a serious threat to India, you hope she would frankly discuss the question with us so that we could examine together possible means to meet that threat without nuclear proliferation and without Indian assumption of the heavy economic and other burdens of a nuclear weapons program." Johnson could also offer to continue to share intelligence with her government on Chinese capabilities and remind her that the US was talking with the Soviet Union about how to ensure the security of nonnuclear weapons states.[220]

On her trip to the US, Gandhi asserted that India did not want to produce nuclear weapons. Her close aide, L. K. Jha, however, added that without another option ensuring nonnuclear states' security, this decision—already under attack in India—would not be politically sustainable. Rusk noted that some sort of joint US-Soviet action vis-à-vis the security of nonnuclear states was not "inconceivable," but there was little interest in Moscow even talking about the subject. He suggested that joint US-UK action could be considered, but it would probably require an alliance. C.S. Jha, the Indian foreign secretary, confirmed that India did not want an alliance and that, as Shastri had previously mentioned, India did not want just a US-UK guarantee.